PROJECT CLOSE-OUT REPORT

SDG Blockchain Accelerator

Cohort 1 & Cohort 2

23
SOLUTION MAKERS
supported across cohorts

26
COUNTRY OFFICES
& institutional partners

9/11
AWARDS WON
at Copenhagen Impact Forum

DELIVERY PARTNERS
UNDP AltFinLab × **EMURGO Labs**

Project Catalyst Fund 13

PROJECT INFORMATION

Delivered by UNDP AltFinLab × EMURGO Labs | Funded by Project Catalyst ; Fund 13

Project Name	SDG Blockchain Accelerator ; Cohort 1 & Cohort 2
Project Number	1300096
Fund	Project Catalyst Fund 13: Cardano Partners: Growth & Acceleration
Delivery Partners	UNDP AltFinLab & EMURGO Labs
Project Managers	Katarina Antic (Emurgo Labs), Teodor Petrovic (UNDP)
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Project URL	https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/
Project Completion Video	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xFIxRla-O-o

Content

1. Executive Summary

The SDG Blockchain Accelerator Cohort 1 & Cohort 2 initiative was delivered to support blockchain-based solutions addressing real Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) challenges across multiple country contexts. The project was designed to help selected Solution Makers move from early concepts, prototypes, or existing products toward stronger pilot readiness, institutional engagement, and realistic implementation pathways.

Across both cohorts, the accelerator supported 23 Solution Makers and engaged 26 UN Country Offices and institutional stakeholders. The supported projects covered a broad range of SDG-aligned use cases, including climate and sustainability reporting, renewable energy certificates, carbon and environmental markets, circular economy, plastics recovery, humanitarian aid distribution, financial inclusion, decentralized identity, digital credentials, project-level evidence systems, supply chain transparency, and public-sector digital trust infrastructure.

The accelerator was not limited to general mentorship or ecosystem visibility. It provided structured product, technical, implementation, and institutional support. Teams received guidance on Cardano architecture, Aiken and Plutus smart contracts, metadata anchoring, token lifecycle design, decentralized identity and credential models, wallet flows, off-chain infrastructure, impact measurement, stakeholder alignment, pilot planning, and continuation strategy.

KEY OUTCOME

A practical bridge was created between three groups that often struggle to work together effectively: development-sector institutions, blockchain ecosystem organizations, and early-stage technology teams.

The project also generated reusable learning for future accelerator design. The evaluation reports from both cohorts show that the strongest projects were not always the most technically complex. They were the teams that combined strong SDG alignment with disciplined execution, stakeholder coordination, realistic pilot scoping, and evidence of deployability.

Overall, this Catalyst-funded project contributed to a practical implementation layer for SDG-aligned blockchain adoption within the Cardano ecosystem.

Accelerator Impact at a Glance

Cohort 1 & Cohort 2 — combined outcomes

23
SOLUTION MAKERS
supported across cohorts

26
UN COUNTRY OFFICES
& institutional stakeholders

9/11
AWARDS WON
Blockchain Impact Forum, CPH

10+
SDG SECTORS
covered by project portfolio

Cohort distribution

Cohort 1	13 teams
Cohort 2	10 teams

Source: SDG Blockchain Accelerator — Cohort 1 & 2 evaluation reports

2. Project Objectives

The main objectives of the project were to:

- Support SDG-focused blockchain projects by helping participating teams refine their product, technical, and implementation approaches.
- Enable real-world Cardano adoption by guiding teams through Cardano ecosystem tooling, architecture choices, smart contract possibilities, metadata anchoring, tokenization models, wallet integrations, and implementation planning.
- Strengthen collaboration between Cardano and UNDP-related stakeholders by supporting structured engagement between Solution Makers, UNDP Country Offices, ecosystem mentors, and technical contributors.
- Improve pilot readiness by helping teams move beyond high-level ideas and toward clearer technical architectures, operational flows, implementation plans, risk assumptions, and measurable impact frameworks.
- Create reusable knowledge and implementation patterns that can support future accelerator cohorts, future pilots, and broader Cardano ecosystem initiatives.
- Demonstrate that blockchain can support development-sector use cases in areas such as sustainability, climate action, credentials, identity, humanitarian support, transparency, supply chain traceability, and financial inclusion.

3. Challenge KPIs and How the Project Addressed Them

Challenge KPI	How the Project Addressed It	Evidence / Outcome
Support blockchain adoption for real-world SDG use cases	The accelerator supported projects working on climate reporting, renewable energy certificates, plastics recovery, credentials, humanitarian aid, digital identity, circular economy, financial inclusion, and supply chain transparency.	Multiple participating teams developed pilot concepts, technical architectures, implementation plans, working prototypes, or continuation pathways linked to SDG use cases.
Increase Cardano ecosystem participation	Teams were introduced to Cardano tools, technical patterns, wallet infrastructure, smart contract models, metadata anchoring, tokenization flows, and ecosystem support.	Participating projects explored Cardano-based architectures, token lifecycle design, metadata anchoring, smart contract flows, and wallet or API integrations.
Enable collaboration between ecosystem actors and institutional stakeholders	The program facilitated engagement between UNDP Country Offices, Solution Makers, Cardano ecosystem organizations, mentors, and implementation partners.	The accelerator created structured collaboration around real development challenges and emerging pilot opportunities.
Support practical technical experimentation	Projects received guidance on smart contracts, metadata, tokenization, identity, credentials, off-chain/on-chain architecture, APIs, and pilot deployment assumptions.	Technical architecture documents, prototype reports, integration reports, and impact frameworks were produced across both cohorts.
Build capacity among participating teams	Teams received product, technical, legal, regulatory, ecosystem, and implementation-oriented mentorship.	Workshops, mentor sessions, office hours, project reviews, and tailored support were delivered during the accelerator lifecycle.
Improve project readiness for pilots and deployment	The accelerator helped teams clarify implementation requirements, stakeholder needs, pilot assumptions, budget constraints, technical dependencies, and next-stage plans.	Several teams progressed toward pilot preparation, follow-on discussions, funding opportunities, ecosystem expansion, or investor-facing opportunities.
Promote ecosystem visibility and engagement	The project created opportunities for teams to engage with broader ecosystem partners, events, and recognition channels.	Participating teams gained visibility through partner discussions, ecosystem events, post-acceleration support, and investor-facing opportunities.

The challenge KPIs were addressed not only through individual deliverables, but also through the creation of a repeatable support model for SDG-oriented blockchain initiatives.

4. Project KPIs and How the Project Addressed Them

Project KPI	Outcome / How It Was Addressed
Support participating teams across Cohort 1 and Cohort 2	23 Solution Makers received structured accelerator support, including product guidance, technical mentorship, architecture review, implementation planning, and stakeholder alignment.
Engage UNDP Country Offices and challenge owners	26 UN Country Offices and institutional stakeholders were engaged across the two cohorts, helping connect solution design to real operational needs.
Deliver product, technical, and implementation support	Teams received support across product strategy, Cardano integration, smart contract design, UX, technical architecture, legal and regulatory considerations, and pilot readiness.
Complete milestone deliverables	Required Catalyst milestone materials were prepared and submitted, including reports, architecture documents, impact frameworks, implementation documentation, and supporting evidence.
Support technical architecture development	Participating teams were supported in defining system architecture, on-chain/off-chain flows, data models, smart contract considerations, wallet interactions, and API integration approaches.
Support Cardano integration planning	Teams received guidance on how Cardano could be used for metadata anchoring, tokenization, smart contracts, digital credentials, wallet flows, and impact-related transaction design.
Improve pilot readiness	Teams clarified their pilot assumptions, target users, stakeholder needs, implementation constraints, technical dependencies, and measurable outputs.
Enable collaboration and ecosystem connectivity	The project helped connect Solution Makers with mentors, ecosystem partners, technical resources, and institutional stakeholders.
Support continuation beyond the accelerator	Several projects continued into pilot planning, follow-on funding discussions, ecosystem expansion, partnership conversations, or implementation refinement after the accelerator.
Capture lessons for future cohorts	Learnings from Cohort 1 and Cohort 2 were captured and used to inform recommendations for future accelerator design, including clearer pilot funding expectations, stronger challenge-owner alignment, improved measurement, and better timing of investor or partner engagement.

5. Evaluation Approach and Performance Evidence

The accelerator used structured evaluation methods to assess both technical feasibility and development-sector relevance. This was important because public-sector and SDG-aligned deployment requires more than a working blockchain prototype. Projects also need institutional alignment, stakeholder engagement, realistic implementation plans, operational readiness, and sustainable continuation pathways.

5.1 Cohort 1 Evaluation Approach

Cohort 1 used a comprehensive evaluation model that combined product evaluation, technical assessment, and UNDP impact assessment. The evaluation tracked each team's technical development, smart contract maturity, data architecture, dashboard readiness, regulatory engagement, adoption risks, and handover capacity.

The evaluation showed that many Cohort 1 projects had strong SDG alignment and clear conceptual value. However, technical maturity varied significantly across teams. High-performing teams such as Plastiks, Karbon Ledger, Zengate, and Genius Tags showed stronger alignment across product, technical, and impact dimensions. Other teams had promising concepts but required more technical refinement, clearer policy alignment, or stronger implementation readiness.

5.2 Cohort 2 Evaluation Approach

Cohort 2 built on prior learning and placed a stronger emphasis on execution readiness, institutional alignment, and pilot feasibility. Projects were assessed using a quantitative scoring model supported by qualitative reviewer comments. The evaluation considered challenge alignment, stakeholder engagement, technical feasibility, funding potential, sustainability, and team execution.

The strongest Cohort 2 projects were CubID Protocol, Plastiks El Salvador, and Fuel Switch, each of which demonstrated strong alignment across evaluation dimensions. Plastiks India and Green Giraffe Zambia also showed solid technical foundations and meaningful development relevance.

KEY LEARNING

Successful projects are those that combine strong conceptual design with disciplined execution, active stakeholder coordination, and real-world validation.

6. Key Support Areas

6.1 Product and Implementation Support

Participating teams received support in refining their product direction, clarifying target users, understanding institutional requirements, and translating high-level blockchain ideas into more practical implementation plans. This included:

- Reviewing project scope and value propositions
- Clarifying pilot objectives and implementation assumptions
- Supporting go-to-market and stakeholder engagement thinking
- Helping teams understand user needs and operational constraints
- Reviewing business model and sustainability considerations
- Supporting the preparation of project documentation for milestone submissions and stakeholder review

6.2 Technical Architecture and Integration Support

A major part of the project involved helping teams define how blockchain infrastructure could fit into their solutions. This included technical architecture reviews, smart contract considerations, off-chain/on-chain design, data flow mapping, and integration planning. Areas covered included:

- Cardano smart contract design considerations
- Aiken-based smart contract experimentation
- Metadata anchoring approaches
- Token minting, burning, transfer, and retirement flows
- Wallet onboarding and transaction flows
- Digital credential and decentralized identity models
- MRV and sustainability data anchoring
- Off-chain database and API architecture
- Front-end and back-end integration considerations
- Pilot deployment assumptions and technical dependencies

6.3 Workshops, Mentorship, and Office Hours

The accelerator included workshops, mentor support, and tailored sessions to help teams progress through the program. These sessions covered product, technical, legal, regulatory, ecosystem, and implementation topics. The support model combined structured sessions with project-specific support. This allowed teams with different maturity levels to receive relevant guidance based on their actual needs.

6.4 Documentation and Reporting

The project produced and supported a range of documentation required for Catalyst reporting and for team-level implementation readiness. These included prototype / proof-of-concept reports, technical architecture documents, integration reports, impact measurement frameworks, workshop materials, implementation planning documents, pilot readiness notes, supporting evidence for milestone submissions, and performance evaluation reports for Cohort 1 and Cohort 2.

6.5 Ecosystem and Stakeholder Engagement

The project helped participating teams engage with the broader Cardano and development-sector ecosystem, including coordination with UNDP Country Offices, collaboration with Cardano ecosystem stakeholders, engagement with mentors and implementation partners, support for project visibility and ecosystem recognition, discussions around pilot continuation and future funding pathways, and post-acceleration support for selected continuation opportunities.

7. Deliverables

The accelerator supported a broad portfolio of projects across two cohorts. This breadth is important because it demonstrates that Cardano infrastructure was explored across multiple SDG-aligned domains rather than a single narrow use case.

SDG-Aligned Sectors Covered

Distribution of supported use cases across the 23-project portfolio

Projects per sector (total = 23)

- **Climate, Carbon & MRV** — 5 projects · 22% of portfolio
- **Plastics & Circular Economy** — 4 projects · 17% of portfolio
- **Renewable Energy Certificates** — 2 projects · 9% of portfolio
- **Financial Inclusion & Humanitarian** — 4 projects · 17% of portfolio
- **Identity & Credentials** — 3 projects · 13% of portfolio
- **Supply Chain & Transparency** — 3 projects · 13% of portfolio
- **Public-Good Infrastructure** — 2 projects · 9% of portfolio

Classification reflects primary use case; many projects span multiple SDG areas.

7.1 Cohort 1 Supported Projects

Project	UNDP / Institutional Match	Main Use Case / Area
Afrikabal	**UNDP Malaysia**	Humanitarian and development-oriented digital infrastructure, including USSD and low-connectivity considerations.
Atlas Ledger	**UNDP Burkina Faso**	Transparent funding, tokenized project flows, and verifiable impact-linked disbursement models.
Cladfy	**UNDP Bangladesh**	Digital records, verification flows, and implementation models connected to public-good service delivery.
Creative Operations / Reloop	**UNDP Georgia**	Circular economy, recycling incentives, reward mechanisms, and treasury-linked environmental workflows.
Genius Tags	**UNDP Malawi**	Traceability, project sharing, user permissions, and transaction logging using Cardano-based infrastructure.
Grinplus	**UNDP Tanzania**	Environmental and sustainability-related data flows, including minting policies and UTxO-based lifecycle modeling.
IotaOrigin	**UNDP Istanbul Regional Hub**	Trust in funding mechanisms and supply chains, including tokenized claim, minting, and redemption concepts.

Project	UNDP / Institutional Match	Main Use Case / Area
Karbon Ledger	**UNDP India**	Carbon and environmental compliance infrastructure, including sensor/AI data, tokenization, off-chain registry, and reporting flows.
Plastiks	**UNDP Armenia**	Plastics recovery, circular economy, recycling traceability, environmental reporting, and impact verification.
Socious Fund	**UNDP Mauritius & Seychelles**	Stablecoin-based crowdfunding, financial inclusion, and off-ramping considerations.
Thallo	**UNDP Tanzania**	Carbon registry infrastructure, environmental agencies engagement, and tokenized carbon credit lifecycle design.
Unicorn.eth	**UNDP Nordic Representation Office**	Donation, revenue distribution, and privacy-preserving funding infrastructure.
Zengate	**UNDP Bangladesh**	Event traceability, open-source frameworks, supply chain, and Cardano eUTxO-based verification flows.
Zengate	**UNDP Ethiopia (During Post Acceleration)**	Event traceability, open-source frameworks, supply chain, and Cardano eUTxO-based verification flows.

7.2 Cohort 2 Supported Projects

Project	UNDP / Institutional Match	Main Use Case / Area
ClimaFi	**UNDP Office of Procurement**	Climate finance infrastructure, digital audit models, and shadow payment / procurement-related climate finance workflows.
CubID Protocol	**UNDP Nigeria**	Digital infrastructure, identity, settlement, and real-world deployment models, including Hydra-related experimentation and field validation.
Plastiks	**UNDP El Salvador**	Plastics recovery, circular economy, environmental impact tracking, and pilot deployment readiness.
Plastiks	**UNDP Zambia (During Post Acceleration)**	Plastics recovery, circular economy, environmental impact tracking, and pilot deployment readiness.
Plastiks	**UNDP Venezuela (During Post Acceleration)**	Plastics recovery, circular economy, environmental impact tracking, and pilot deployment readiness.

Project	UNDP / Institutional Match	Main Use Case / Area
ClimaFi	**Better Than Cash Alliance**	Climate finance and financial inclusion alignment, with institutional relevance and future adoption potential.
Fuel Switch	**UNDP Bosnia and Herzegovina**	Renewable energy certificates, sustainability reporting, tokenization, and auditable energy-related claims.
TradeChainX	**UNDP Ethiopia**	Supply chain transparency, MRV, verification flows, and project-level evidence systems.
Green Giraffe Zambia	**UNDP Angola**	Environmental and sustainability use cases connected to implementation planning and operational partnerships.
Plastiks	**UNDP India**	Plastics recovery, environmental reporting, and scaling potential across a major market context.
xCapit	**UNDP Malawi**	Financial inclusion, humanitarian-oriented wallet infrastructure, and low-tech / offline-access considerations.
SALA	**UNDP Bosnia and Herzegovina**	Education credentials, institutional credentialing, digital trust, and verifiable certificate models.

7.3 Selected Project Highlights

While every supported team received tailored guidance, the following profiles illustrate the depth and diversity of work delivered under the accelerator. They are representative rather than exhaustive, and are drawn from both cohorts to show the range of SDG-aligned use cases advanced on Cardano infrastructure.

Plastiks (Cohort 1 ; UNDP Armenia; Cohort 2 ; UNDP El Salvador, UNDP India, UNDP Venezuela)

Plastiks worked on plastics recovery and circular-economy infrastructure, using Cardano to support recycling traceability, environmental reporting, and impact verification. The team progressed from environmental-impact concepts toward pilot-ready deployment models, and emerged as one of the strongest performers across both cohorts. Its continuation pipeline became the most extensive in the program, advancing toward an additional MOU with UNDP Zambia & Venezuela and reaching four use-case duplication opportunities (UNDP Venezuela is still in progress) across multiple UNDP Country Offices ; a clear demonstration of how a single solution can be replicated across country contexts.

CubID Protocol (Cohort 2 ; UNDP Nigeria)

CubID Protocol focused on digital identity, settlement, and real-world deployment models, including experimentation with Hydra for scalability and field validation in a live context. It was among the strongest Cohort 2 projects, demonstrating alignment across challenge relevance, technical feasibility, and execution. Its continuation pathway points toward becoming the first project to connect with the NCCC in Nigeria, an institutional milestone with significant signalling value for public-sector blockchain adoption.

Karbon Ledger (Cohort 1 ; UNDP India)

Karbon Ledger built carbon and environmental-compliance infrastructure combining sensor and AI data capture, tokenization, an off-chain registry, and structured reporting flows. It showed strong technical maturity and a clear pathway from data collection to verifiable, tokenized environmental claims, making it one of the more technically advanced teams in Cohort 1.

Zengate (Cohort 1 ; UNDP Bangladesh)

Zengate worked on event traceability, open-source frameworks, and supply-chain verification built on Cardano's eUTxO model. The team combined strong engineering with a reusable, open framework approach, and continued beyond the program toward a pilot opportunity with UNDP Ethiopia.

Genius Tags (Cohort 1 ; UNDP Malawi)

Genius Tags delivered traceability, project sharing, user-permission management, and transaction logging on Cardano infrastructure. The team advanced toward concrete deployment, progressing to a pilot with UNDP Malawi and Syria ; an example of a Cohort 1 project converting accelerator support into a live field pilot.

Unicorn.eth (Cohort 1 ; UNDP Nordic Representation Office)

Unicorn.eth built donation, revenue-distribution, and privacy-preserving funding infrastructure. It became one of the clearest continuation successes of the program, deploying its first pilot with UNDP OP-CCIT and securing USD 300,000 in a quadratic funding round ; direct evidence that accelerator support can translate into funded, deployed outcomes.

Fuel Switch (Cohort 2 ; UNDP Bosnia and Herzegovina)

Fuel Switch addressed renewable energy certificates and sustainability reporting, using tokenization to support auditable, verifiable energy-related claims. It ranked among the strongest Cohort 2 teams on execution and institutional alignment, with a credible path toward auditable energy-transition reporting.

SALA (Cohort 2 ; UNDP Bosnia and Herzegovina)

SALA worked on education credentials, institutional credentialing, and verifiable certificate models built on digital-trust infrastructure. The team progressed toward a pilot with the University of Sarajevo, demonstrating relevance to verifiable academic and institutional credentials in a real deployment setting.

Additional Notable Teams

Thallo (UNDP Tanzania) advanced carbon-registry infrastructure and tokenized carbon-credit lifecycle design; Green Giraffe Zambia (UNDP Angola) developed environmental and sustainability use cases with strong implementation planning and operational partnerships; and IotaOrigin (UNDP Istanbul Regional Hub) explored trust mechanisms for funding and supply chains through tokenized claim, mint, and redemption concepts. Across the wider portfolio, teams such as Afrikabal, Atlas Ledger, Cladfy, Creative Operations/Reloop, Grinplus, Socious Fund, ClimaFi, TradeChainX, and xCapit explored complementary use cases spanning humanitarian infrastructure, transparent funding, circular economy, climate finance, supply-chain transparency, and financial inclusion.

7.4 Documentation Deliverables in Detail

A substantial body of documentation was produced and submitted through milestone reporting across both cohorts. These materials served two purposes simultaneously: satisfying Catalyst milestone requirements, and giving teams practical, reusable implementation assets. The principal document types delivered were:

- Technical architecture documents ; describing on-chain/off-chain boundaries, data models, smart-contract considerations, wallet interactions, and integration approaches for each supported solution.
- Prototype and proof-of-concept reports ; capturing what was built or simulated, the technical assumptions tested, and the results observed.
- Integration reports ; documenting how Cardano components (metadata anchoring, tokenization, smart contracts, wallet flows) connected to off-chain systems and external data sources.
- Impact-measurement frameworks ; defining what each project would measure, the indicators of success, and how impact could be evidenced before and after deployment.
- Implementation and pilot-readiness notes ; clarifying target users, stakeholder needs, technical dependencies, operational constraints, and the assumptions to validate before a pilot.
- Workshop materials ; covering product, technical, legal, regulatory, ecosystem, and implementation topics, reusable across cohorts.
- Performance-evaluation reports ; formal assessments of both cohorts, combining quantitative scoring with qualitative reviewer commentary across multiple dimensions
- Together, these documents form the formal evidence package referenced throughout this report and are consolidated in the repositories listed in the Relevant Links section.

7.5 Evidence and Output Status

Evidence (GitHub & Notion pages). The formal evidence package was submitted progressively through prior Catalyst milestones and is consolidated in two repositories: Cohort 1 Evidence Folder and Cohort 2 Evidence Folder. These contain technical architecture documents, prototype / proof-of-concept reports, integration reports, impact-measurement frameworks, and workshop evidence.

8. Usage & Key Achievements

8.1 Strengthened Institutional Collaboration

One of the most important achievements was the creation of a working collaboration model between blockchain ecosystem builders and institutional stakeholders. Through the accelerator, participating projects were able to engage with UNDP-related challenges and better understand the realities of deploying technology in development-sector environments.

This is important because institutional adoption requires more than a technical proof of concept. Teams need to understand procurement constraints, implementation realities, stakeholder incentives, data quality issues, regulatory considerations, reporting requirements, and local operational contexts. The accelerator helped create this bridge and provided teams with a more realistic understanding of what it takes to move from blockchain concept to institutional pilot.

8.2 Practical Cardano Exploration Across Multiple Use Cases

The accelerator supported practical exploration of Cardano infrastructure across a diverse range of use cases, including:

- Renewable energy certificates and sustainability reporting
- Climate and MRV-related data systems

- Carbon and environmental compliance infrastructure
- Plastics recovery and circular economy models
- Humanitarian aid distribution and financial inclusion
- Decentralized identity and digital credentials
- Education and institutional credentialing
- Project-level evidence and transparency systems
- Supply chain and impact verification workflows
- Public-good funding and traceability systems

This diversity helped demonstrate that Cardano can be explored as infrastructure for real-world utility across multiple SDG-aligned sectors.

8.3 Technical Architecture and Implementation Readiness

A major achievement was the development of technical architecture and implementation materials that helped teams clarify how their solutions could be built or extended. Instead of remaining at a conceptual level, teams were supported in thinking through what should happen on-chain versus off-chain, which data should be anchored or represented on Cardano, whether tokens, credentials, metadata, or smart contracts were appropriate, how users would interact with wallets or applications, how pilots could be measured, which technical components would be required for implementation, and what assumptions needed to be validated before deployment.

8.4 Ecosystem Recognition and Awards

A major Cohort 1 achievement was the strong external recognition received by accelerator teams at the Blockchain Impact Forum in Copenhagen, organized by the Blockchain for Good Alliance (BGA). Cohort 1 teams made an outstanding impression, winning 9 out of 11 awards across multiple partner categories.

This recognition matters because it shows that the accelerator's value extended beyond internal reporting and milestone completion. Cohort 1 teams were externally validated by ecosystem, investor, media, and venture-building partners. The awards also created tangible continuation value for teams, including grants, incubation access, investor-readiness support, media visibility, mentoring, and potential follow-on funding pathways.

The BGA Top 3 teams received direct entry into the BGA Incubation 2026 Spring Cohort, including a USD 10,000 equity-free grant per team, mentorship and tailored support across go-to-market strategy, business development, and tokenomics, visibility through BGA, Bybit, and partner communication channels, and potential consideration for the 2026 Ascend Program offering up to USD 50,000 in additional grants. BGA also provided a USD 2,000 recognition incentive per winning Solution Maker team.

The GSR Foundation Award included USD 10,000 for the winning team, with potential additional support and investment consideration on an ad hoc basis. Draper University offered the winning team a fast-track opportunity to the final selection round for its five-week Hero Training program in Silicon Valley, including access to the Draper University ecosystem, mentoring sessions with executives and investors, and potential investment opportunities starting from USD 100,000 with no equity taken upfront.

The Nordic Blockchain Association awards provided conference access, NBA membership, and investor pitch and strategy support for top-performing teams. Cointelegraph provided media visibility grants, including a USD 10,000 media grant for first place and USD 6,000 media grants for second and third place.

8.5 Stronger Pilot Pipeline and Continuation Potential

Several projects continued beyond the accelerator through follow-on discussions, pilot planning, funding opportunities, ecosystem expansion activities, and post-acceleration support. Following the acceleration period, the project included six weeks of post-acceleration support. This phase helped teams continue strategic conversations, refine pilot opportunities, prepare for investor-facing opportunities, and build on the institutional relationships developed during the program. Examples of continuation outcomes included:

- Plastiks progressing toward an additional MOU with UNDP Zambia, bringing its total to four use-case duplication opportunities across multiple UNDP Country Offices.
- ZenGate continuing work toward a pilot opportunity with UNDP Ethiopia.
- SALA progressing toward a pilot with the University of Sarajevo.
- Cardano accelerator teams being invited to Proof of Talk in Paris to pitch in front of a curated group of investors.
- Cohort 1 teams receiving major recognition at the Blockchain Impact Forum in Copenhagen, winning 9 out of 11 awards across BGA, Draper University, GSR Foundation, Nordic Blockchain Association, and Cointelegraph categories.
- Further pilot preparation with institutional or ecosystem partners and continued technical refinement and implementation planning.

8.6 Lessons Captured for Future Accelerator Design

The work completed during Cohort 1 and Cohort 2 generated valuable lessons for future accelerator programs. Important learnings included:

- Challenge-owner commitment should be validated earlier in the process.
- Pilot budget expectations should be clearer before teams are selected.
- Teams with existing products and mature implementation capacity can move faster toward pilots.
- Smaller or less mature teams need a different support track and different success expectations.
- Investor and partner events are more useful later in the program, once teams have clearer pilot plans, working outputs, and specific asks.
- Technical reporting should focus on meaningful activity, not vanity metrics.
- Mainnet activity, contract execution, token lifecycle events, and metadata-anchored actions are stronger indicators of real blockchain adoption than simple wallet creation.

9. Measurable and Qualitative Impact

9.1 Measurable Impact Areas

Impact Area	Outcome
Number of cohorts supported	Cohort 1 and Cohort 2 were supported under the accelerator initiative.
Number of participating teams supported	23 Solution Makers received product, technical, and implementation support.
Number of UN Country Offices / institutional stakeholders engaged	26 UN Country Offices and institutional stakeholders were engaged across the two cohorts.
Number of SDG-aligned sectors covered	Projects covered climate, sustainability, plastics recovery, renewable energy, carbon markets, financial inclusion, humanitarian aid, credentials, identity, circular economy, and supply chain transparency.
Technical deliverables produced	Multiple technical architecture documents, prototype reports, integration reports, impact frameworks, implementation documents, and evaluation reports were produced and submitted through milestone reporting.
Workshops and support sessions delivered	Product, technical, legal, regulatory, ecosystem, and implementation-focused sessions were delivered across the accelerator lifecycle.
Projects progressing beyond the accelerator	Several teams continued into pilot preparation, follow-on discussions, funding opportunities, ecosystem expansion, investor-facing opportunities, and external recognition pathways. Examples include Plastiks, ZenGate, SALA, Cardano teams invited to Proof of Talk in Paris, and Cohort 1

Impact Area	Outcome
	teams winning 9 out of 11 awards at the Blockchain Impact Forum in Copenhagen.
Ecosystem engagement	The project supported engagement between Solution Makers, Cardano ecosystem actors, UNDP stakeholders, mentors, and external partners.

9.2 Qualitative Impact

The accelerator's qualitative impact was significant because it helped create a more realistic pathway for blockchain adoption in development-sector environments. The project helped teams move from abstract blockchain narratives toward more practical questions:

- What is the actual problem being solved?
- Who are the users and stakeholders?
- Which part of the workflow benefits from blockchain?
- What data needs to be trusted, verified, or made auditable?
- What belongs on-chain and what should remain off-chain?
- What technical architecture is realistic for a pilot?
- What does success look like after the accelerator?

By helping teams answer these questions, the project improved implementation readiness and reduced the risk of building blockchain solutions that are technically interesting but operationally weak.

9.3 Ecosystem Impact

The project created value for the Cardano ecosystem by introducing Cardano infrastructure to real-world use cases connected to global development challenges. This helped position Cardano as a potential infrastructure layer for transparent sustainability reporting, digital trust systems, tokenized impact assets, verifiable credentials, humanitarian and financial inclusion tools, climate and MRV-related evidence systems, public-good technology infrastructure, and supply chain transparency and traceability. This is valuable because it expands the Cardano ecosystem beyond purely financial or speculative applications and demonstrates its relevance to public-good and institutional use cases.

10. What Was Achieved Compared to the Original Scope

The project remained aligned with its original purpose: supporting SDG-oriented blockchain projects and enabling practical Cardano ecosystem engagement through the accelerator. The main achievements compared to the original scope were:

- Accelerator activities were delivered across Cohort 1 and Cohort 2.
- 23 Solution Makers were supported across SDG-aligned use cases.
- 26 UN Country Offices and institutional stakeholders were engaged.
- Participating teams received product, technical, and implementation support.
- Required Catalyst milestone materials were prepared and submitted.
- Technical documentation and architecture outputs were completed.

- Teams were supported in understanding Cardano integration possibilities.
- UNDP-related institutional engagement was supported.
- Pilot readiness and continuation pathways were developed for selected teams.
- Lessons were captured for future accelerator improvement.

Some teams progressed faster than others depending on their maturity, available resources, clarity of pilot ownership, and technical readiness. This is expected in an accelerator environment, especially when working with institutional partners and early-stage or mixed-maturity solutions. Where projects did not reach full deployment during the accelerator period, the work still created value by clarifying technical requirements, identifying implementation gaps, developing architecture, and preparing teams for future pilot or funding opportunities.

11. Challenges and Learnings

11.1 Different Team Maturity Levels

Participating teams had different levels of product maturity, technical capacity, and pilot readiness. Some teams already had existing products and could focus on adapting or extending their work. Others required more foundational support around product definition, architecture, or stakeholder alignment. This created an important learning for future cohorts: mature teams and early-stage teams should ideally be supported through different tracks with different expectations.

11.2 Pilot Budget and Ownership Clarity

One of the biggest learnings was that pilot planning is stronger when country office commitment, stakeholder ownership, and budget expectations are clarified earlier. Without clear pilot ownership and budget visibility, teams can still make technical progress, but the path to implementation becomes harder. Future cohorts should validate whether the challenge owner has a real operational need, whether there is internal capacity to support a pilot, whether pilot funding or co-funding is available, and whether the project has a clear post-accelerator implementation path.

11.3 Technical Readiness Requires More Than Blockchain Knowledge

The accelerator confirmed that successful blockchain implementation requires more than smart contracts or token design. Teams also need clear user journeys, data governance models, off-chain infrastructure, security and risk planning, operational workflows, stakeholder onboarding, compliance awareness, and measurement frameworks. This is why the project combined product, technical, and implementation support rather than treating blockchain as a standalone technology layer.

11.4 Institutional Readiness Is as Important as Technical Readiness

A recurring challenge across both cohorts was that technical prototypes could move faster than institutional adoption environments. Public-sector and development-sector stakeholders often need time to clarify governance, legal comfort, operational responsibility, procurement pathways, data ownership, and budget ownership. For future cohorts, institutional readiness should be treated as a formal part of project selection and pilot planning.

11.5 Execution Discipline Matters More Than Conceptual Strength

The performance evaluations show that strong concepts alone were not enough. The strongest teams were those that maintained consistent delivery, communicated clearly with stakeholders, responded to feedback, and translated concepts into practical pilot plans. This is a key lesson for future program design: accelerator support should reward execution discipline and realistic scoping, not only innovation narratives.

12. Sustainability & Continuation Model

The six-week post-acceleration period has already shown that several teams have credible continuation pathways. The next stage is therefore focused on converting this momentum into concrete pilots, signed agreements, investor conversations, and measurable ecosystem outcomes.

12.1 Continued Pilot Support

Several teams are already continuing toward pilots, implementation discussions, or further technical development. The documentation and architecture work completed during the accelerator can support these next steps. Current continuation examples include:

- Plastiks progressing toward another MOU with UNDP Zambia, bringing its use-case duplication pipeline to four opportunities across multiple UNDP Country Offices.
- ZenGate working toward a pilot with UNDP Ethiopia.
- SALA progressing toward a pilot with the University of Sarajevo.
- Cupid Protocol working towards being the first ever project to connect with NCCC in Nigeria.
- Genius Tags deploying a pilot with UNDP Malawi and Syria.
- Unicorn.eth deployed their first pilot with UNDP OP-CCIT, securing $300,000 in a quadratic funding round.
- Cardano teams preparing for investor-facing pitching opportunities at Proof of Talk in Paris.
- Cohort 1 teams building on recognition from the Blockchain Impact Forum in Copenhagen, where they won 9 out of 11 awards across BGA, Draper University, GSR Foundation, Nordic Blockchain Association, and Cointelegraph categories.

12.2 Improved Future Cohort Design

Lessons from Cohort 1 and Cohort 2 can inform future accelerator structures, including clearer selection criteria, separate tracks for mature and early-stage teams, earlier challenge-owner interviews, stronger pilot budget validation, more structured technical readiness checks, and better alignment between project maturity and expected outcomes.

12.3 Stronger Measurement and Reporting

Future accelerator work can include improved reporting of meaningful on-chain activity, including contract execution, token lifecycle events, and metadata-anchored actions. This would help demonstrate whether projects are truly using Cardano infrastructure in production or pilot contexts.

12.4 Expanded Ecosystem Collaboration

The project created relationships and working patterns that can support further collaboration between Cardano ecosystem actors, UNDP stakeholders, implementation partners, and SDG-focused Solution Makers.

12.5 Continued Focus on Real-World Use Cases

Future work should continue focusing on high-value development-sector use cases where blockchain can provide clear benefits, including climate and MRV systems, digital credentials, aid distribution, financial inclusion, public procurement transparency, sustainability reporting, project-level evidence and auditability, supply chain traceability, and circular economy and waste recovery.

12.6 Permanent Storage and Reusability

All program documentation and evidence are permanently stored in public GitHub repositories, in addition to the Accelerator Wiki/Curriculum and all the Cardano Video Tutorials (Cohort 1, Cohort 2, Accelerator Wiki, Cardano Video Tutorials), allowing future cohorts and ecosystem teams to reuse the architecture patterns, evaluation frameworks, and implementation templates produced.

13. Why This Project Is Important

This project matters because it helped demonstrate a practical pathway for connecting blockchain infrastructure with real-world development challenges.

Many blockchain projects remain disconnected from real institutional needs. They may have strong technical ideas, but they often lack access to implementation environments, pilot owners, impact measurement, and operational feedback. At the same time, development organizations often see potential in emerging technologies but need help understanding which solutions are practical, credible, and deployable.

> **THE BRIDGE**
> The SDG Blockchain Accelerator helped reduce this gap.

Through Cohort 1 and Cohort 2, the project created a structured environment where Solution Makers could work closer to institutional challenges, receive technical and product guidance, and better understand how Cardano infrastructure could be applied to real SDG-related problems.

The community should be excited about this project because it shows Cardano being used in a serious and impact-oriented context. The work supported use cases connected to climate action, sustainability, renewable energy, financial inclusion, credentials, humanitarian aid, transparency, circular economy, and supply chain traceability. These are areas where digital trust, auditability, and decentralized infrastructure can provide meaningful value when applied correctly.

The project also matters because it generated reusable learning for the ecosystem. It showed what works, what needs improvement, and what future accelerator programs should do differently to increase the likelihood of real deployment.

In simple terms, this project helped move Cardano closer to real institutional adoption by supporting the people, processes, documentation, technical planning, and ecosystem relationships required for serious implementation.

14. Relevant Links and Supporting Materials

The project's supporting evidence has been submitted progressively through previous Catalyst milestone submissions. This includes technical architecture documents, prototype / proof-of-concept reports, impact measurement frameworks, integration reports, workshop evidence, and other supporting documentation.

Please Find below all the Relevant links for your convenience:

Project Catalyst Link: https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/

Project Number: 1300096

Previous Catalyst milestone submissions

- **Milestone 1 PoA:** https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/milestones/1/poa-1
- **Milestone 2 PoA:** https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/milestones/2
- **Milestone 3 PoA:** https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/milestones/3
- **Milestone 4 PoA:** https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/milestones/4
- **Milestone 5 PoA:** https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/milestones/5
- **Final Milestone PoA:** https://milestones.projectcatalyst.io/projects/1300096/milestones/6

Master evidence folders:

- **Cohort 1 Evidence Folder:** https://github.com/EA-Emurgo-Labs/Catalyst-M4-Submission/tree/main
- **Cohort 2 Evidence Folder:** https://github.com/EA-Emurgo-Labs/Catalyst-M5-Submission/tree/main
- **Close-Out Video:** https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xFIxRla-O-o

15. Solution Maker Testimonials

Direct feedback from participating Solution Makers provides qualitative evidence of the accelerator's value. The testimonials below were shared by founders and product leads across both cohorts, reflecting the program's impact on their strategy, technical direction, and institutional engagement.

Link to Post HERE

Link to Post HERE

Link to Post [HERE]

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16. Closing Statement

IN SUMMARY

The SDG Blockchain Accelerator Cohort 1 & Cohort 2 project successfully delivered a structured, multi-stakeholder accelerator model for SDG-aligned blockchain innovation that conforms with UN agencies internal processes and standards. It supported 23 Solution Makers, engaged 26 UN Country Offices and institutional stakeholders, produced substantial technical and implementation documentation, and created continuation momentum for selected teams beyond the formal program period.

Most importantly, the project demonstrated that blockchain adoption in development-sector contexts requires more than technology. It requires institutional alignment, realistic pilot design, technical discipline, impact measurement, stakeholder trust, and long-term implementation pathways.

By combining Cardano ecosystem expertise with UNDP-related development challenges and hands-on team support, the project created practical evidence that blockchain infrastructure can contribute to transparency, accountability, digital trust, and measurable impact across multiple SDG-aligned sectors.

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